

Michigan - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-15 underlying quality with a higher offensive floor than 2025, but a top-five schedule and major defensive/professional turnover make the win total much less stable than the ranking.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 16 (718 points) · SP+ No. 15
Returning production	63% (No. 19) overall · Off. 72% (No. 6) · Def. 55% (No. 57)
Primer power rating	+17.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.4 wins · likely 7-5 to 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar overall quality with a better offensive continuity signal and a less stable defense/staff environment.
Confidence	Medium

2026 identity: OC Jason Beck builds around QB Bryce Underwood/RB Jordan Marshall and spacing/RPO concepts, while DC Jay Hill rebuilds around DE John Henry Daley, DL Trey Pierce and a veteran secondary core.

Bottom line: Michigan has top-15 talent and a settled QB1, but a new staff/rebuilt front seven face SP+ SOS No. 5.

Beats expectations if: QB Bryce Underwood improves in Beck's offense, C Brady Guarnera/OT Andrew Sprague stabilize the OL, and DE John Henry Daley/DL Trey Pierce plus the veteran secondary absorb the defensive losses.

Disappoints if: Unsettled OL combinations stall the offense and the rebuilt linebacker/front groups prove too thin against a top-five schedule.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Bryce Underwood is the established returning QB1/captain, and Michigan returns 72% of offensive production (No. 6).
- 2 ♦ New staff:** Kyle Whittingham, Jason Beck and Jay Hill are all new external hires; Beck is explicitly supported as the offensive play caller.
- 3 Returning production:** Defensive returning production is 55% (No. 57) after major losses including EDGE Derrick Moore, LB Jaishawn Barham/LB Jimmy Rolder and DT Rayshaun Benny.
- 4 ? OL questions:** WR Andrew Marsh/WR JJ Buchanan lead the targets; OL, linebacker and safety combinations remain open.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No. 5, with Oklahoma/Iowa/Penn State before late trips to Oregon and Ohio State.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (7-2 Big Ten)	● Good
Scoring	27.5 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	396.9 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	210.2 YPG · 5.4 YPC	● Elite
Pass efficiency	7.14 YPA · 11 TD / 10 INT	● Below average
Third downs	43.6%	● Very good
Scoring defense	20.4 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	323.3 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	111.9 YPG · 3.4 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	211.4 YPG · 6.45 YPA · 17 TD allowed	● Good / above average

Michigan was run-led and defense-first: rushing offense ranked No. 14, pass efficiency No. 96, while the defense was top-30 in scoring, total and rush defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+7.62 · No. 15	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.141 · No. 18	● Very good
Off. success rate	47.0% · No. 28	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	13.3% · No. 39	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	11.8% · No. 13	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	+7.59 · No. 12	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.126 · No. 19	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	41.1% · No. 64	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.1% · No. 17	● Very good
Havoc created	16.9% · No. 40	● Good / above average

Advanced-stat read: Michigan’s offense rated No. 15 adjusted/No. 18 EPA despite No. 96 pass efficiency. The defense was top-15 adjusted but only average by success rate, sharpening the 2026 QB-efficiency and defensive-rebuild questions.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Kyle Whittingham - from Utah HC	● ↔ The résumé supports a high staff-quality grade, but a full program/system transition prevents treating the change as an automatic upgrade.
OC / play-caller	◆ Jason Beck - from Utah OC; offensive play-caller	● ↑ Beck inherits a returning QB1 and strong offensive production signal, and the reported spacing/RPO package offers a path to improve the 2025 passing profile.
DC	◆ Jay Hill - from BYU DC	● ↔ CB Hill is a credible coordinator/install owner, but defensive personnel turnover and an unresolved live-caller designation keep the projection less stable.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR JJ Buchanan	Utah	● ↑ Established top target alongside WR Andrew Marsh.
Out	To	Loss
TE Marlin Klein	NFL (Houston), Round 2, No. 59	● ↓ Starting TE/captain leaves a meaningful role to TE Zack Marshall/TE Hogan Hansen.
TE/FB Max Bredeson	NFL (Minnesota), Round 5, No. 159	● ↓ Captain/TE-FB starter departs, reducing package continuity.
RB Justice Haynes	Georgia Tech	● ↔ RB Justice Haynes leaves, but RB Jordan Marshall remains the established lead.
OL Giovanni El-Hadi	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Veteran OL departure adds to unsettled guard combinations.

Offensive net: ● ↑ Better QB/skill continuity, offset by TE/interior-line losses and an unsettled best five.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DE John Henry Daley	Utah	● ↑ Projected starting edge with AP/Walter Camp second-team All-America recognition; workload remains managed.
◆ CB Smith Snowden	Utah	● ↔ Major secondary addition with an open corner/nickel role.
◆ S Chris Bracy	Memphis	● ↔ Adds to an open safety alignment.
◆ LB Nathaniel Staehling	North Dakota State	● ↔ Significant candidate in the rebuilt linebacker competition.
Out	To	Loss
EDGE Derrick Moore	NFL (Detroit), Round 2, No. 44	● ↓ Captain/10-sack edge is a major loss.
LB Jaishawn Barham	NFL (Dallas), Round 3, No. 92	● ↓ Major linebacker contributor leaves through the third round.
LB Jimmy Rolder	NFL (Detroit), Round 4, No. 118	● ↓ Eleven-start, 73-tackle linebacker leaves a major hole.
DT Rayshaun Benny	NFL (Baltimore), Round 7, No. 250	● ↓ Thirteen-start interior defender departs from a rebuilding front.
LB Ernest Hausmann	Eligibility / graduation	● ↓ Veteran/captain linebacker exits.

Defensive net: ● ↓ High-end anchors remain, but 55% defensive returning production and open LB/safety roles lower continuity.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Jason Beck’s offense uses horizontal spacing, jet sweeps/perimeter screens and RPO/second-option/QB-pull elements, with physical WR blocking emphasized as part of the run-game structure.	QB Underwood/RB Marshall continuity, WR Marsh/WR Buchanan as established targets and C Guarnera/OT Sprague as strong OL anchors.	LT/guard combinations and WR3 remain unsettled, and the new scheme must improve the 2025 No.96 pass-efficiency profile.
Defense	Jay Hill owns a newly installed base package with opponent-specific calls layered in; personnel quality is strongest at edge/DB and less settled at linebacker/safety depth.	DE Daley, DL Pierce, CB Jyaire Hill, DB Berry and S Rod Moore provide credible high-leverage anchors.	The unit is replacing several NFL/pro-level front-seven contributors and has open LB/safety competitions.
Special teams	New primary specialists after Zvada/Tarr turnover.	Butkowski carries Groza recognition.	SP+ No.113 and projected new K/P roles create genuine preseason uncertainty.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↑	High	QB Bryce Underwood returns as the established starter/captain after 2,428 passing yards.
RB	● A–	● ↔	High	RB Jordan Marshall returns after 932 yards/10 TD, with RB Savion Hiter adding rotation depth.
WR	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	WR Andrew Marsh/WR JJ Buchanan headline the room, but WR3 remains open after a poor 2025 pass-efficiency season.
TE	● B–	● ↓	Medium	TE Zack Marshall/TE Hogan Hansen step forward after TE Marlin Klein and TE/FB Max Bredeson departed.
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	OT Andrew Sprague/C Brady Guarnera are strong anchors, but LT and guard combinations remain unsettled.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↓	Medium	DE John Henry Daley/DL Trey Pierce/DL Enow Etta anchor a front replacing EDGE Derrick Moore and several veterans.
LB	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	LB Nathaniel Staehling and other viable options must replace LB Jaishawn Barham/LB Jimmy Rolder/LB Ernest Hausmann.
Secondary	● B+	● ↔	Medium	CB Jyaire Hill/DB Zeke Berry/S Rod Moore anchor a talented group with fluid safety/nickel roles.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	New K/P projections replace proven specialists; SP+ ranks the unit No. 113.
Coaching	● A–	● ↔	Medium	HC Kyle Whittingham, OC Jason Beck and DC Jay Hill are highly regarded but all new to Michigan.
Overall	● A–	● ↔	Medium	SP+ No.15 supports top-15 caliber, with strong QB/RB and high-end anchors; top-five SOS and defensive/staff turnover cap confidence.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: preseason honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Bryce Underwood	QB	● High-end conference starter / breakout candidate	Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	Returning starter and captain after 2,428 passing yards; Maxwell and Walter Camp watchlists.
Jordan Marshall	RB	● High-end conference back	Maxwell	Returning captain/lead back after 932 rushing yards and 10 TD; safest offensive volume role.
Andrew Marsh	WR	● High-end receiving target	Paul Hornung	Established top target with Paul Hornung recognition; central to raising the passing game.
JJ Buchanan (TR: Utah)	WR	● High-end transfer target	John Mackey (prior TE designation)	Current roster lists him at WR and camp information places him with WR Andrew Marsh atop the target hierarchy; Mackey recognition reflects his prior TE designation.
Andrew Sprague	OT	● National-level tackle	Walter Camp 2nd team · Outland	Walter Camp second-team preseason All-American and Outland watchlist; one of the two clearest settled OL spots.
★ John Henry Daley (TR: Utah)	DE	● National defensive star	AP 2nd team · Walter Camp 2nd team · Bednarik · Nagurski	AP/Walter Camp second-team All-American with Bednarik/Nagurski recognition; medically cleared but camp workload was managed.
Jyaire Hill	CB	● High-end conference corner	Bednarik · Jim Thorpe	Bednarik/Thorpe watchlists and leadership council; most established returning cover defender.
Rod Moore	S	● Veteran secondary anchor	-	Captain and medically cleared; his health-managed return materially stabilizes an otherwise changing back end.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Brutal relative to a top-15 roster; the schedule is the main reason the expected record is closer to eight wins than to the team's power-rating rank.
Difficulty	● 10/10 · Brutal · SP+ SOS No. 5
Hardest stretch	at Oregon → UCLA → at Ohio State (Nov. 14-28): two road games against the No.2 and No.1 SP+ teams with only UCLA at home between them.
Swing games	Oklahoma (home), Iowa (home), Penn State (home)
Advantage	Four straight home games open the season, and the Oct. 10 bye precedes Penn State/Indiana at home.
Expected	7.4 wins · likely 7-5 to 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Michigan's brand and top-15 model profile can support premium pricing, but the top-five SOS and new-staff/defensive-turnover risk are legitimate reasons not to price the Wolverines as a stable elite team yet.
Back them when	QB Underwood's passing efficiency is improving and the OL combination has stabilized, especially in home games where Michigan's run/RPO structure can keep the offense on schedule against similarly rated opponents.
Fade/pass when	Facing elite fronts/quarterbacks before the new LB/safety structure and special teams prove stable, or when a line assumes the 2025 top-15 adjusted defense survived the personnel turnover intact.
Key monitor	final OL five, LB/safety winners, S Rod Moore and DE John Henry Daley workload/availability, WR3 hierarchy, specialist stability, defensive live caller only if later explicitly identified
Week 1 baseline	vs. Western Michigan: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Michigan -28.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Michigan's top-15 case starts with QB Bryce Underwood/RB Jordan Marshall and enough offensive skill talent for OC Jason Beck to improve a passing game that lagged in 2025. The defense still has real anchors in DE John Henry Daley, DL Trey Pierce, CB Jyaire Hill, DB Zeke Berry and S Rod Moore, but it is replacing much more proven production than the offense. That makes Michigan a strong team with unusual transition risk: a completely new HC/OC/DC trio, unsettled OL/LB/safety combinations and **SP+ SOS No. 5**. The likely range is closer to **7-5 to 8-4** than the top-15 power rating alone suggests, with upside if the new systems and rebuilt front seven settle quickly.

About this primer

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